

Mushroom

Fungi are not animals and they're not plants. They are made up of masses of tiny branching threads. We usually notice them only when they produce mushrooms, which are their fruiting bodies. Poisonous mushrooms, like the colorful fly agaric mushroom, are often called toadstools—be careful never to touch or pick them.

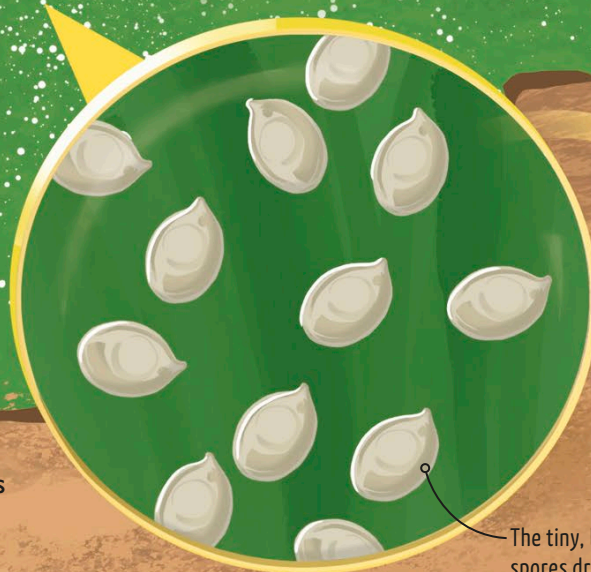
Fly agaric mushrooms grow alone or in small clusters on the forest floor.



The bright red color of the cap warns that the fly agaric mushroom is very poisonous.

Settling

When the spores settle in new places, they germinate (sprout) and produce fine threads called hyphae. As the hyphae grow, they branch and spread out, feeding on moisture and nutrients in the soil.



The tiny, lightweight spores drift far and wide on the wind.

Cloud of spores

A fly agaric mushroom releases millions of white spores, which are sort of like seeds. The spores blow away on the wind, and only a few will end up growing into new fungi.

See also

Find out about plants that reproduce using spores (50-51).

Birch tree The fly agaric often grows near birch trees. The hyphae wrap around tree roots and supply the trees with nutrients from the soil. In return, the fungus receives sugars made in the trees' leaves.



Devil's fingers

This creepy fungus is covered in gooey slime that smells like rotting flesh. The slime contains the spores of the fungus. Beetles, flies, and slugs attracted by the fumes get covered in slime and carry off the spores when they leave.

